and will play a due and responsible role in this regard.'[126] India's reluctance to arm Kabul, according to some, was a 'strategic volte-face' by New Delhi.[127]

India had vacillated tremendously before gifting four Mi-25 attack helicopters to Kabul in December 2015, which was also treated as a 'one-off' arrangement in light of Afghanistan's evolving political and security situation.[128] Popular analyses emphasise Pakistan's sensitivities as the causal factor for India's reluctance in supplying such weaponry.[129] While it is true that Pakistan's perceptions about such an arms transfer was not lost on Indian policymakers, this geopolitical angle was not critical in restricting India from supplying weapons to Kabul.[130] India dithered mostly due to the other two drivers of its Afghanistan policy, i.e. domestic Afghan politics and international posture towards Kabul coupled with India's own capacity constraints. Before detailing the exact operational and systemic causes that delayed India's supply of lethal weaponry to Afghanistan, the following paragraphs outline the contours of debate between partisans and conciliators on this issue. Despite holding different policy core beliefs on how to engage with Afghanistan, the partisans and conciliators agreed on the legitimacy of India's arms transfer to Kabul. But Afghanistan's domestic political situation, worsening of relations with Pakistan, and the drastic reduction among NATO member's political will to continue fighting India's complicated options.

The motivations for partisans and conciliators to supply weapons to Kabul were radically different. The partisan's logic was rooted in their belief that Pakistan-sponsored groups should be actively contained in Afghanistan. Such advocacy had three angles to it. Firstly, India should call Pakistan's bluff and not be scared that supplying weapons to Kabul would destabilise the region. Secondly, providing weapons to the Afghan forces would allow India to buttress Kabul's capacity to keep the Taliban at bay. Thirdly, India needed to step up to the occasion as a regional power and secure its interests in Afghanistan. Though few policymakers categorically stated that India should equip Afghanistan as a counter-weight to Pakistan, the hope of pulling Pakistan into a military quagmire in Afghanistan remained potent.[131] The lack of ordnance factories in Afghanistan only made it imperative for India, the partisans argued, to increase Kabul's military capacities.[132] Though such support would not allow Afghanistan to effectively trade artillery fire with the Pakistan army at the border, it would allow